

Lucky handed me a bundle of notes. 'Here, hold this in your palm and fire it away with your finger in the direction of the girl you like. If you want to, you can go right on to the floor and shower it on your favourite,' he said.

'I am fine, why don't you throw it on my behalf?' I suggested.

Our drinks had come by then. I took a couple of sips, trying to look away from the dance floor.

'Look there,' Lucky tugged at my elbow a couple of minutes later, 'Payal is now wearing a different dress. She has taken the trouble to change . . . all for you . . . some effect you must have had on her . . . she is looking at you seductively from time to time . . . what is wrong with you? You are simply ignoring her,' he said.

'Look, Lucky, I just want to leave this place,' I told him firmly.

He stared at me momentarily and said: 'Okay, I give in. But let's at least finish this drink.'

'Promise?' I asked.

'Of course,' he said.

I took my glass and drained it in a few gulps.

'There, I have finished my drink. Come, let's leave,' I said.

Lucky was dumbfounded.

'You are in some hurry, I must say . . . but be a little patient and let me finish my drink,' Lucky said. He took ten minutes to finish it.

As we rose to leave, a waitress (no doubt a retired dance girl now past her prime) asked Lucky for a tip. He reluctantly gave her Rs 50. I thought that was rather cheap. The waitress stood there, looked at the money in her palm and then at Lucky, expecting him to be a bit more generous. Lucky ignored her and had begun to walk away when the lady told him that the tip was too low. This infuriated him. He looked at me and said, '*Saali* . . . she says the tip is too low.' Then, turning to her, he told her in a slightly raised voice: 'I keep telling my boss that my salary is too low . . . but that bastard refuses me, saying he pays his employees only what they are worth. Why the hell should I pay you anything more than you are worth?' I was surprised at Lucky's needless outburst, and had never seen this side of him. It made me all the more wary of him. He need not have paid her more, but neither did he have to insult her.

I was glad that we were finally leaving the place. But Lucky was in no hurry.